

Bartleby, the Scrivener

Herman Melville · 1853

First published: Putnam's Monthly, Nov–Dec 1853

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Piazza_Tales/Bartleby_the_Scrivener (revision 12985183), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 11–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Bartleby, the Scrivener suggest about passive resistance?
- What does Bartleby, the Scrivener suggest about alienation in modern work?
- What does Bartleby, the Scrivener suggest about charity and responsibility?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* Bartleby, the Scrivener	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*passive resistance* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to Bartleby, the Scrivener

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Herman Melville's life or times connects to passive resistance in “Bartleby, the Scrivener”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (passive resistance, alienation in modern work, charity and responsibility).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

Herman Melville was born in New York City on 1 August 1819. After his merchant father's bankruptcy and death he went to sea, sailing on a whaler in 1841 and jumping ship in the Marquesas; his South Seas adventures Typee (1846) and Omoo (1847) were popular. Moby-Dick (1851) and the works that followed sold poorly, and from 1866 he worked for nineteen years as a customs inspector in New York. He died on 28 September 1891, largely forgotten; his reputation was revived in the 1920s.

Historical and cultural context

Wall Street in the 1840s–50s was becoming the centre of American finance. Before photocopiers and typewriters, legal documents were copied by hand by scriveners (copyists) paid by the page. Melville wrote the story after the commercial failure of Moby-Dick (1851) and Pierre (1852), when he himself was being asked to write what the market wanted.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published anonymously in two parts in Putnam's Monthly Magazine, November and December 1853, as "Bartleby, the Scrivener. A Story of Wall-Street"; collected in The Piazza Tales (1856).

Then: Modestly noticed; Melville's reputation was in decline and he died in 1891 largely forgotten.

Now: Since the Melville revival of the 1920s it has been one of the most discussed American stories; "I would prefer not to" has become a catchphrase for passive resistance, cited in discussions of the Occupy Wall Street movement (2011).

Overview (spoiler-free)

An elderly Wall Street lawyer narrates his encounter with Bartleby, a quiet copyist he hires, who one day begins answering every request with "I would prefer not to."

Main themes

- alienation and work.
- passive resistance.
- charity and its limits.

Why it matters

The story speaks to modern experiences of meaningless work, burnout and the limits of compassion.

Spoilers · teacher only

Bartleby stops working entirely and refuses to leave; the lawyer moves his office rather than evict him. Bartleby is taken to the Tombs prison, where he refuses to eat and dies. The lawyer then hears a rumour that Bartleby once worked in the Dead Letter Office.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open Bartleby, the Scrivener: Have you ever wanted to just say no to a task without explaining why?
Prompt: Before we open Bartleby, the Scrivener: Have you ever wanted to just say no to a task without explaining why?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
unreliable narrator; passive resistance; alienation; scrivener; characterization.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Herman Melville was born in New York City on 1 August 1819. After his merchant father's bankruptcy and death he went to sea, sailing on a whaler in 1841 and jumping ship in the Marquesas; his South Seas adventures Typee (1846) and Omoo (1847) were popular. Moby-Dick (1851) and the works that followed sold poorly, and from 1866 he worked for nineteen years as a customs inspector in New York. He died on 28 September 1891, largely forgotten; his reputation was revived in the 1920s. The world of the book. Wall Street in the 1840s–50s was becoming the centre of American finance. Before photocopiers and typewriters, legal documents were copied by hand by scriveners (copyists) paid by the page. Melville wrote the story after the commercial failure of Moby-Dick (1851) and Pierre (1852), when he himself was being asked to write what the market wanted. Publication and reception. First published anonymously in two parts in Putnam's Monthly Magazine, November and December 1853, as "Bartleby, the Scrivener. A Story of Wall-Street"; collected in The Piazza Tales (1856). Then: Modestly noticed; Melville's reputation was in decline and he died in 1891 largely forgotten. Now: Since the Melville revival of the 1920s it has been one of the most discussed American stories; "I would prefer not to" has become a catchphrase for passive resistance, cited in discussions of the Occupy Wall Street movement (2011).

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Ere introducing the scrivener, as he first appeared to me, it is fit I" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator says that before introducing the scrivener, as he first saw him, it is fitting that he describe himself. Next, craft. I notice "Ere" and "it is fit," formal phrases that show a careful, self-regarding speaker. The strongest word is "fit": it shows his concern with what is proper, the value Bartleby will challenge. Then, effect. What does this opening tell us about the narrator? My answer: The story is told by the lawyer, who talks about himself first; we see Bartleby only through a comfortable man's eyes.

> *Ere introducing the scrivener, as he first appeared to me, it is fit I* (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 2)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Ere introducing the scrivener, as he first appeared to me, it is fit I" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator says that before introducing the scrivener, as he first saw him, it is fitting that he describe himself. Next, craft. I notice "Ere" and "it is fit," formal phrases that show a careful, self-regarding speaker. The strongest word is "fit": it shows his concern with what is proper, the value Bartleby will challenge. Then, effect. What does this opening tell us about the narrator? My answer: The story is told by the lawyer, who talks about himself first; we see Bartleby only through a comfortable man's eyes.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): An elderly Wall Street lawyer narrates his encounter with Bartleby, a quiet copyist he hires, who one day begins answering every request with "I would prefer not to." Themes to track: alienation and work.: passive resistance.: charity and its limits.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: passive resistance. Prediction: Bartleby's polite "I would prefer not to" will unsettle the Wall Street lawyer more than open defiance would. Question: why can't the narrator simply fire him?
Task: Set up a reading journal for Bartleby, the Scrivener: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: passive resistance. Prediction: Bartleby's polite "I would prefer not to" will unsettle the Wall Street lawyer more than open defiance would. Question: why can't the narrator simply fire him?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does Bartleby, the Scrivener still matter? The story speaks to modern experiences of meaningless work, burnout and the limits of compassion.
Anchor question: Why might Bartleby, the Scrivener still be taught today?
Facilitation: The story speaks to modern experiences of meaningless work, burnout and the limits of compassion.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
Melville wrote "Bartleby" in 1853 after his story Moby-Dick sold poorly. How might his career at that point shape a story about a copyist who refuses to work? Answer: Accept answers such as: he was frustrated with writing what the market wanted; the story can be read as about a writer's refusal; Wall Street was changing work into dull copying.
Exit ticket: Melville wrote "Bartleby" in 1853 after his story Moby-Dick sold poorly. How might his career at that point shape a story about a copyist who refuses to work?
Answer: Accept answers such as: he was frustrated with writing what the market wanted; the story can be read as about a writer's refusal; Wall Street was changing work into dull copying.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: Bartleby, the Scrivener.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Herman Melville" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Herman-Melville); The Melville Society (https://melvillesociety.org/); Melville Society, Melville's works (https://melvillesociety.org/); Library of America, Melville: Pierre, Israel Potter, The Piazza Tales (https://www.loa.org/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Links to Occupy Wall Street are a cultural reference, not part of the story's original reception.

Lesson 2: Bartleby, the Scrivener

Focus: refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve

Objective: Students will analyze how point of view develops in “Bartleby, the Scrivener” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (death in prison, alcohol or drugs (mentioned), suicide (mentioned in lesson text)): Sensitive content: Death in prison. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. This section mentions drinking or a drug (“… irth charged him so thoroughly with an irritable, brandy-like disposition, that all subsequent p…”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it. This lesson mentions suicide or self-harm. Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes death in prison.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this chapter is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

An elderly Wall Street lawyer hires a pale copyist, Bartleby, who works well until he begins answering every request with 'I would prefer not to.' He stops copying, lives in the office, and will not leave. Unable to dismiss him, the lawyer moves his offices; Bartleby is taken to the Tombs prison, where he refuses to eat and dies. The lawyer learns Bartleby once worked in the Dead Letter Office: 'Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity!'

Background: Published in Putnam's Monthly in 1853, as Wall Street offices filled with clerks doing copying by hand.

Significance: Read as an early story of modern alienation and of nonviolent refusal; the narrator's reliability is central.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to alienation and work because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes death in prison. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to alienation and work because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: benevolently — in a kind, well-meaning way; chimeras — wild, impossible dreams or fantasies; obtruded — pushed forward unwelcome; unexampled — never seen before; unequaled; interment — the ritual placing of a corpse in a grave. "obtruded": Origin of "obtrude": Latin obtrūdō ("thrust off or against"). "interment": From Old French enterrement "burial," from enterrer "to put in the earth" (Latin terra "earth").
Words: benevolently: in a kind, well-meaning way · chimeras: wild, impossible dreams or fantasies · obtruded: pushed forward unwelcome · unexampled: never seen before; unequaled · interment: the ritual placing of a corpse in a grave

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in Putnam's Monthly in 1853, as Wall Street offices filled with clerks doing copying by hand. Read as an early story of modern alienation and of nonviolent refusal; the narrator's reliability is central. Narrator: The lawyer is comfortable, cautious and self-justifying; the story is as much about him as about Bartleby. Setting: The office's windows face walls (one white, one black), an image of a walled-in life. Repetition: "I would prefer not to" becomes almost comic, then tragic. Watch for walls and dead letters: blocked communication and lost lives.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "I would prefer not to" slowly and put it in my own words: Asked to do his work, Bartleby says he would prefer not to. Next, craft. I notice the phrase is mild and conditional, not "I will not," which makes it impossible to argue with. The strongest word is "prefer": it is a word of polite choice, and it turns refusal into something gentle and maddening. Then, effect. What is the effect of Bartleby's polite refusal? My answer: The effect of Bartleby's polite refusal is to paralyze the lawyer, who cannot handle a refusal that is calm and unexplained; the line exposes how much his office depends on everyone obeying.

> *I would prefer not to* *(Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "I would prefer not to" slowly and put it in my own words: Asked to do his work, Bartleby says he would prefer not to. Next, craft. I notice the phrase is mild and conditional, not "I will not," which makes it impossible to argue with. The strongest word is "prefer": it is a word of polite choice, and it turns refusal into something gentle and maddening. Then, effect. What is the effect of Bartleby's polite refusal? My answer: The effect of Bartleby's polite refusal is to paralyze the lawyer, who cannot handle a refusal that is calm and unexplained; the line exposes how much his office depends on everyone obeying.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Pairing Bartleby with "humanity" makes him a representative of everyone. Ask: How does this line connect to alienation and work? Expected: Copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. (The last line.)

> *Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity* *(Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Pairing Bartleby with "humanity" makes him a representative of everyone.
Ask: How does this line connect to alienation and work?
Expected answer: Copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. (The last line.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the story for narrator, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Bartleby, the Scrivener develops the idea of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. When the text says “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485), it shows this directly. Hearing of the Dead Letter Office, he exclaims "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men," and ends "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity," linking one clerk to everyone.

Task: Annotate the story for narrator, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Bartleby, the Scrivener develops the idea of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. When the text says “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485), it shows this directly. Hearing of the Dead Letter Office, he exclaims "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men," and ends "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity," linking one clerk to everyone.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses? Ask: is Bartleby's refusal resistance or illness?

Anchor question: Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses?

Facilitation: Ask: is Bartleby's refusal resistance or illness?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. (“Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men”, Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. (“Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men”, Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how narrator shapes refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Key takeaway: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Narrator:** The lawyer is comfortable, cautious and self-justifying; the story is as much about him as about Bartleby.
- **Setting:** The office's windows face walls (one white, one black), an image of a walled-in life.
- **Repetition:** "I would prefer not to" becomes almost comic, then tragic.

Themes and how they develop

- **alienation and work:** copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning.

Symbols and motifs

- **walls and dead letters:** blocked communication and lost lives.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51) The refrain.
- “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485) The lawyer's reflection.
- “Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486) The last line.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition.
Evidence: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485)
Reasoning: Hearing of the Dead Letter Office, he exclaims "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men," and ends "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity," linking one clerk to everyone.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
benevolently (adverb)	in a kind, well-meaning way	*At any rate, upon the occasion in question, I strove to drown my exasperated feelings towards the scrivener by benevolently construing his conduct.*	

chimeras (noun)	wild, impossible dreams or fantasies	*These sad fancyings—chimeras, doubtless, of a sick and silly brain—led on to other and more special thoughts, concerning the eccentricities of Bartleby.*	
obtruded (verb)	pushed forward unwelcome	*I believe that this wise and blessed frame of mind would have continued with me, had it not been for the unsolicited and uncharitable remarks obtruded upon me by my professional friends who visited the rooms.*	"obtruded": Origin of "obtrude": Latin obtrūdō ("thrust off or against"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/obtrude#Etymology)
unexampled (adjective)	never seen before; unequaled	*Instantly it occurred to me, that his unexampled diligence in*	
interment (noun)	the ritual placing of a corpse in a grave	*Imagination will readily supply the meager recital of poor Bartleby's interment.*	"interment": From Old French enterrement "burial," from enterrer "to put in the earth" (Latin terra "earth"). (Online Etymology Dictionary (hand-checked note), https://www.etymonline.com/word/interment)
surmises (noun)	guesses	*Though concerning the self-indulgent habits of Turkey I had my own private surmises, yet touching Nippers I was well persuaded that whatever might be his faults in other respects, he was, at least, a temperate young man.*	"surmises": Origin of "surmise": Old French surmis. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/surmise#Etymology)
penniless (adjective)	not having enough money to pay for necessities	*myself to be ignominiously repulsed by this lean, penniless wight?—my*	
persists (verb)	continues firmly	*B—" pointing to the lawyer, "has turned him out of his room, and he now persists in haunting the building generally, sitting upon the banisters of the stairs by day, and sleeping in the entry by night.*	
pyramids (noun)	pyramid-shaped piles	*The heart of the eternal pyramids, it seemed, wherein, by some strange magic, through the clefts, grass-seed, dropped by birds, had sprung.*	
forebodings (noun)	a feeling of evil to come	*Full of forebodings, I replied that I was.*	

Discussion questions

1. Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses?
2. Where does point of view appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with passive resistance?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What is the narrator's profession? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A Wall Street lawyer
2. What is Bartleby's job? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Scrivener, or copyist
3. What is Bartleby's famous reply? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: I would prefer not to
4. What does the narrator finally do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Moves his offices away
5. Where had Bartleby worked before, according to rumor? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The Dead Letter Office
6. Retell the three most important events of “Bartleby, the Scrivener” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: An elderly Wall Street lawyer hires a pale copyist, Bartleby, who works well until he begins answering every request with 'I would prefer not to.' He stops copying, lives in the office, and will not leave. Unable to dismiss him, the lawyer moves his offices; Bartleby is taken to the Tombs prison, where he refuses to eat and dies. The lawyer learns Bartleby once worked in the Dead Letter Office:…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “Bartleby, the Scrivener”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “Bartleby, the Scrivener” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “At any rate, upon the occasion in question, I strove to drown my exasperated feelings towards the scrivener by benevolently construing his conduct.” What does “benevolently” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: benevolently: in a kind, well-meaning way.
10. Reread: “These sad fancyings—chimeras, doubtless, of a sick and silly brain—led on to other and more special thoughts, concerning the eccentricities of Bartleby.” What does “chimeras” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: chimeras: wild, impossible dreams or fantasies.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “Bartleby, the Scrivener” suggest about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Read as an early story of modern alienation and of nonviolent refusal; the narrator's reliability is central.
2. Find one example of point of view in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
3. How does the characterization in this story shape what we understand about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51): The refrain. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “Though concerning the self-indulgent habits of Turkey I had my own private surmises, yet touching Nippers I was well persuaded that whatever might be his faults in other respects,…”, why might Melville have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “Bartleby, the Scrivener”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An elderly Wall Street lawyer hires a pale copyist, Bartleby, who works well until he begins answering every request with 'I would prefer not to.' He stops copying, lives in the office, and will not leave. Unable to dismiss him, the lawyer moves his offices; Bartleby is taken to the Tombs prison,…
6. As the opening story, what does “Bartleby, the Scrivener” set up that the rest of Bartleby, the Scrivener will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485): The lawyer's reflection. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486): The last line. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Have you ever wanted to say 'I would prefer not to' to a demand? What happens when someone simply refuses?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.

9. Where does symbolism appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with passive resistance? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51): The refrain. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in Putnam's Monthly in 1853, as Wall Street offices filled with clerks doing copying by hand. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485): The lawyer's reflection. On setting: The office's windows face walls (one white, one black), an image of a walled-in life. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Read as an early story of modern alienation and of nonviolent refusal; the narrator's reliability is central.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486): The last line. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51): The refrain. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “Bartleby, the Scrivener” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485): The lawyer's reflection. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “Bartleby, the Scrivener”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2,

SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486): The last line. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to alienation in modern work: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Melville need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51): The refrain. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the point of view in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485): The lawyer's reflection. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “Bartleby, the Scrivener” treats refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Bartleby, the Scrivener see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486): The last line. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve passive resistance? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51): The refrain. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485): The lawyer's reflection. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Herman Melville about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Useful evidence: "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity" (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486): The last line. Theme link: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Point of view:** look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What is the narrator's profession?
   A. A doctor
   B. A banker
   C. A Wall Street lawyer
   D. A judge

   Key: C (A Wall Street lawyer)
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Where had Bartleby worked before, according to rumor?
   A. A bank
   B. A ship
   C. A prison
   D. The Dead Letter Office

   Key: D (The Dead Letter Office)
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 24: "In fact, _____ as a rash, restive horse is said to feel his oats, so Turkey felt his coat." Word bank: precisely, staggered, impertinence, gentlemanly
   Key: precisely
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 1: "I have known very many of them, _____ and privately, and if I pleased, could relate divers histories, at which good-natured gentlemen might smile, and sentimental souls might weep." Word bank: constitution, uncarpeted, precisely, professionally
   Key: professionally
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "B—' pointing to the lawyer, 'has turned him out of his room, and he now _____ in haunting the building generally, sitting upon the banisters of the stairs by day, and sleeping in the entry by night." Word bank: benevolently,

persists, chimeras, obtruded

Key: persists

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What is Bartleby's famous reply?

   A. I cannot

   B. I would prefer not to

   C. Leave me alone

   D. Not today

   Key: B (I would prefer not to)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Imagination will readily supply the meager recital of poor Bartleby's _____." Word bank: benevolently, chimeras, obtruded, interment

   Key: interment

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Though concerning the self-indulgent habits of Turkey I had my own private _____, yet touching Nippers I was well persuaded that whatever might be his faults in other respects, he was, at least, a temperate young man." Word bank: chimeras, obtruded, benevolently, surmises

   Key: surmises

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 152? "I _____ to my desk, and sat there in a deep study."

   A. staggered

   B. contained

   C. turning

   D. mechanical

   Key: A (staggered)

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What does the narrator finally do?

    A. Fires everyone

    B. Pays Bartleby to leave

    C. Calls the police at once

    D. Moves his offices away

    Key: D (Moves his offices away)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 169 reveal about the character or situation? "His steadiness, his freedom from all dissipation, his incessant industry (except when he chose to throw himself into a standing revery behind his screen), his great stillness, his unalterableness of demeanor under all circumstances, made…" Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 169) shows the situation turning on passive resistance: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The words "unalterableness" and "circumstances" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "I would prefer not to" (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The refrain. The evidence is "I would prefer not to" (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51). This develops alienation and work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 1 reveal about the character or situation? "Bartleby was one of those beings of whom nothing is ascertainable, except from the original sources, and in his case those are very small." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 1) shows the situation turning on passive resistance: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The words "ascertainable" and "original" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.
14. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 202 shapes its tone: "It was rather weak in me I confess, but his manner on this occasion" Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words "occasion" and "confess" (paragraph 202) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to passive resistance: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.
15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze the word choice in "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity" (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The last line. The evidence is "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity" (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486). This develops alienation and work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. It reads more sharply beside "I would prefer not to" (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51), which shows the same situation from another angle.
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 109 to the story's treatment of passive resistance: "As yet I had never of my personal knowledge known him to be outside of my office." Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 109) develops passive resistance: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Its words "knowledge" and "personal" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "If I turn him away, the chances are he will fall in with some less indulgent employer, and then he will be rudely…" (paragraph 111), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating passive resistance as central.
17. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What is Bartleby's job?

    A. Clerk in a shop
    B. Scrivener, or copyist
    C. Accountant
    D. Messenger

    Key: B (Scrivener, or copyist)
18. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "myself to be ignominiously repulsed by this lean, _____ wight?—my" Word bank: benevolently, chimeras, penniless, obtruded
    Key: penniless
19. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485: "Dead _____! does it not sound like dead men"
    Key: letters
20. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What can you infer from this line? "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men" (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The lawyer's reflection. The evidence is “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485). This develops alienation and work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning.

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 17 shapes its tone: “Surely, sir, a blot or two of a warm afternoon is not to be” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “afternoon” (paragraph 17) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to passive resistance: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 173 shapes its tone: “The cushioned seat of a rickety old sofa in one corner bore the faint impress of a lean, reclining form.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “reclining” and “cushioned” (paragraph 173) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to passive resistance: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 263 to the story's treatment of passive resistance: “At the expiration of that period, I peeped behind the screen, and lo!” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 263) develops passive resistance: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Its words “expiration” and “peeped” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “There was no vulgar bullying, no bravado of any sort, no choleric hectoring, and striding to and fro across the…” (paragraph 284), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating passive resistance as central.

24. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 104: “You hear what they say,’ said I, _____ towards the screen, ‘come” Word bank: staggered, constitution, turning, afternoon
    Key: turning

25. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485).
    Sample answer: Hearing of the Dead Letter Office, he exclaims "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men," and ends "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity," linking one clerk to everyone. The evidence is “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485) — The lawyer's reflection. This develops alienation and work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning.

26. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The refrain. The evidence is “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51). This develops alienation and work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The words “prefer” and “would” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. Hearing of the Dead Letter Office, he exclaims "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men," and ends "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity," linking one clerk to everyone.

27. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 40? “Where there are two or more scriveners in an office, they assist each other in this _____, one reading from the copy, the other holding the original.”

    A. contained

B. precisely

C. surrounding

D. examination

Key: D (examination)

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 27 shapes its tone: “His father was a carman, ambitious of seeing his son on the bench instead of a cart, before he died.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “ambitious” and “instead” (paragraph 27) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to passive resistance: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.
29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Synthesis: trace how alienation and work develops from the opening of “Bartleby, the Scrivener” to its ending. Use one quotation from each part.
    Sample answer: Near the start, “I would prefer not to” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 51) — The refrain. Later, “Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 486) — The last line. Copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning.
30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 289 to the story's treatment of passive resistance: “Yet a certain melancholy mixed with this: I was almost sorry for my brilliant success.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 289) develops passive resistance: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Its words “melancholy” and “brilliant” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Bartleby,’ said I, entering the office, with a quietly severe expression, ‘I am seriously displeased.” (paragraph 297), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating passive resistance as central.
31. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] In the line “Instantly it occurred to me, that his unexampled diligence in”, what does “unexampled” most nearly mean?

    A. pushed forward unwelcome

    B. never seen before; unequaled

    C. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies

    D. in a kind, well-meaning way

    Key: B (never seen before; unequaled)

32. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.5] Which literary element does this describe in “Bartleby, the Scrivener”? The lawyer is comfortable, cautious and self-justifying; the story is as much about him as about Bartleby.

    A. Conflict

    B. Simile

    C. Narrator

    D. Metaphor

    Key: C (Narrator)

33. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 41 to the story's treatment of passive resistance: “One object I had in placing Bartleby so handy to me behind the screen, was to avail myself of his services on such trivial occasions.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 41) develops passive resistance: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of

meaning. Its words “occasions” and “services” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “So calling Nippers from the other room, the paper was speedily examined.” (paragraph 57), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating passive resistance as central.

34. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Which literary element does this describe in “Bartleby, the Scrivener”? The office's windows face walls (one white, one black), an image of a walled-in life.

    A. Simile

    B. Allusion

    C. Characterization

    D. Setting

    Key: D (Setting)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	1, 17, 10, 7, 9, 18, 19, 3, 20, 11, 13, 12, 21, 22, 15, 23	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	2, 8, 4, 9, 5, 3, 24, 1, 6, 11, 13, 22, 25, 15, 26, 23	recall 9, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	2, 4, 9, 18, 6, 24, 27, 8, 11, 13, 25, 21, 15, 28, 26, 29	recall 8, inference 2, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	27, 1, 10, 2, 3, 5, 12, 13, 11, 28, 14, 15, 22, 23, 30, 16	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	17, 31, 27, 7, 8, 12, 21, 28, 25, 15, 14, 32, 23, 16, 30, 33	recall 5, inference 1, analysis 6, synthesis 4
College Freshman	9, 3, 10, 7, 1, 17, 11, 14, 21, 22, 15, 28, 23, 29, 33, 30	recall 6, inference 1, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	17, 18, 7, 1, 6, 28, 22, 34, 21, 14, 15, 26, 33, 23, 16, 30	recall 5, inference 0, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Junior	6, 1, 7, 8, 17, 28, 21, 15, 22, 25, 14, 34, 23, 30, 16, 33	recall 5, inference 0, analysis 7, synthesis 4
College Senior	7, 1, 17, 6, 24, 15, 25, 28, 22, 34, 14, 21, 30, 16, 23, 33	recall 5, inference 0, analysis 7, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	24, 7, 1, 17, 27, 12, 11, 21, 28, 22, 32, 15, 16, 30, 23, 33	recall 5, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Bartleby, the Scrivener,” how does Melville show refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the point of view you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): In Bartleby, the Scrivener, how does Melville develop the idea of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the point of view in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Bartleby, the Scrivener develops the idea of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of Bartleby, the Scrivener (where it begins, turns and ends) and its point of view shape the reader's understanding of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what Bartleby, the Scrivener suggests about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's point of view and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Herman Melville uses point of view in Bartleby, the Scrivener to complicate the reader's understanding of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Bartleby, the Scrivener within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Bartleby, the Scrivener alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve follows or bends those conventions, using the point of view as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Bartleby, the Scrivener and its treatment of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's point of view and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Bartleby, the Scrivener as evidence for a larger claim about refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Bartleby, the Scrivener as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Bartleby, the Scrivener.

SAT-style questions

1. *I believe that this wise and blessed frame of mind would have continued with me, had it not been for the unsolicited and uncharitable remarks obtruded upon me by my professional friends who visited the rooms.*

As used in the text, what does the word "obtruded" most nearly mean?

A. a feeling of evil to come

B. continues firmly

C. pushed forward unwelcome

D. pyramid-shaped piles

2. *Though concerning the self-indulgent habits of Turkey I had my own private surmises, yet touching Nippers I was well persuaded that whatever might be his faults in other respects, he was, at least, a temperate young man. But indeed, nature herself seemed to have been his vintner, and at his birth charged him so thoroughly with an irritable, brandy-like disposition, that all subsequent potations were needless. When I consider how, amid the stillness of my chambers, Nippers would sometimes impatiently rise from his seat, and stooping over his table, spread his arms wide apart, seize the whole desk, and move it, and jerk it, with a grim, grinding motion on the floor, as if the table were a perverse voluntary agent, intent on thwarting and vexing him; I plainly perceive that for Nippers, brandy and water were altogether superfluous.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "Bartleby, the Scrivener"?

A. Refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve

B. Science that poisons love

C. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

D. A crime that backfires

SAT key: 1. C (pushed forward unwelcome); 2. A (Refusal as a mystery the narrator cannot solve)

Unit test

Bartleby, the Scrivener: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 60? “I heard a slow scrape of his chair legs on the _____ floor, and”

   A. staggered
   B. proverbially
   C. contained
   D. uncarpeted

   Key: D (uncarpeted)

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 28: “In answer to my _____, a motionless young man one morning, stood upon my office threshold, the door being open, for it was summer.” Word bank: uncarpeted, turning, professionally, advertisement

   Key: advertisement

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 24? “But with all his failings, and the annoyances he caused me, Nippers, like his compatriot Turkey, was a very useful man to me; wrote a neat, swift hand; and, when he chose, was not deficient in a _____ sort of deportment.”

   A. uncarpeted
   B. gentlemanly
   C. surrounding
   D. examination

   Key: B (gentlemanly)

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 57: “Had there been the least uneasiness, anger, impatience or _____ in his manner; in other words, had there been any thing ordinarily human about him, doubtless I should have violently dismissed him from the premises.” Word bank: constitution, staggered, impertinence, afternoon

   Key: impertinence

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 10? "Indeed, not only would he be reckless and sadly given to making blots in the _____, but some days he went further, and was rather noisy."

   A. staggered

   B. impertinence

   C. afternoon

   D. mechanical

   Key: C (afternoon)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 111: "But one _____ the evil impulse in me mastered me, and the following little scene ensued:" Word bank: afternoon, precisely, uncarpeted, surrounding

   Key: afternoon

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 24: "Though of a very ingenious _____ turn, Nippers could never get this table to suit him." Word bank: turning, mechanical, staggered, afternoon

   Key: mechanical

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 27? "Indeed, to this quick-witted youth the whole noble science of the law was _____ in a nut-shell."

   A. constitution

   B. proverbially

   C. contained

   D. precisely

   Key: C (contained)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 7? "Hence, though I belong to a profession _____ energetic and nervous, even to turbulence, at times, yet nothing of that sort have I ever suffered to invade my peace."

   A. examination

   B. impertinence

   C. advertisement

   D. proverbially

   Key: D (proverbially)

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 110? "My mind then ran on in reveries concerning the probable effects upon the human _____ of living entirely on ginger-nuts."

    A. professionally

    B. gentlemanly

    C. constitution

    D. examination

    Key: C (constitution)

11. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 9: "Owing to the great height of the _____ buildings, and my chambers being on the second floor, the interval between this wall and mine not a little resembled a huge square cistern." Word bank: uncarpeted, professionally, surrounding, turning

    Key: surrounding

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 24 reveal about the character or situation? "The truth was, I suppose, that a man of so small an income, could not afford to sport such a lustrous face and a lustrous coat at one and the same time." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 24) shows the situation turning on charity and responsibility: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The words "lustrous" and "suppose" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 57 reveal about the character or situation? "So calling Nippers from the other room, the paper was speedily examined." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 57) shows the situation turning on alienation in modern work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The words "examined" and "speedily" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

14. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 284 reveal about the character or situation? "There was no vulgar bullying, no bravado of any sort, no choleric hectoring, and striding to and fro across the apartment, jerking out vehement commands for Bartleby to bundle himself off with his beggarly traps." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 284) shows the situation turning on alienation in modern work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The words "apartment" and "hectoring" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

15. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 179 reveal about the character or situation? "And when at last it is perceived that such pity cannot lead to effectual succor, common sense bids the soul rid of it." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 179) shows the situation turning on charity and responsibility: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The words "effectual" and "perceived" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 285 shapes its tone: "One moment I thought it would prove a miserable failure, and Bartleby would be found all alive at my office as usual; the next moment it seemed certain that I should see his chair empty." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "miserable" and "failure" (paragraph 285) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to charity and responsibility: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 8 shapes its tone: "Some time prior to the period at which this little history begins, my avocations had been largely increased." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "avocations" and "increased" (paragraph 8) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than

neutral. That weight points the reader to alienation in modern work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 10 to the story's treatment of charity and responsibility: “Turkey was a short, pursy Englishman of about my own age, that is, somewhere not far from sixty.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 10) develops charity and responsibility: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Its words “somewhere” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Surely, sir, a blot or two of a warm afternoon is not to be” (paragraph 17), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating charity and responsibility as central.

19. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in the story?

    A. “Surely, sir, a blot or two of a warm afternoon is not to be”

    B. “Owing to the great height of the surrounding buildings, and my chambers being on the second floor, the interval between this wall and mine…”

    C. “Turkey was a short, pursy Englishman of about my own age, that is, somewhere not far from sixty.”

    D. “Indeed, not only would he be reckless and sadly given to making blots in the afternoon, but some days he went further, and was rather noisy.”

    Key: B (“Owing to the great height of the surrounding buildings, and my chambers being on the second floor, the interval between this wall and mine…”)

20. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 89 shapes its tone: “He briefly gave me to understand that on that point my judgment was” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “understand” and “judgment” (paragraph 89) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to charity and responsibility: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 170 shapes its tone: “One was kept by a woman residing in the attic, which person weekly scrubbed and daily swept and dusted my apartments.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “apartments” and “residing” (paragraph 170) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to alienation in modern work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 111 shapes its tone: “If I turn him away, the chances are he will fall in with some less indulgent employer, and then he will be rudely treated, and perhaps driven forth miserably to starve.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “indulgent” and “miserably” (paragraph 111) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to alienation in modern work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 241 to the story's treatment of alienation in modern work: “I thought to myself, surely I must get rid of a demented man, who already has in some degree turned the tongues, if not the heads of myself and clerks.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 241) develops alienation in modern work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Its words “demented” and “already” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “In

plain fact, he had now become a millstone to me, not only useless as a necklace, but afflictive to bear." (paragraph 262), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating alienation in modern work as central.

24. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 262 shapes its tone: "In plain fact, he had now become a millstone to me, not only useless as a necklace, but afflictive to bear." Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words "afflictive" and "millstone" (paragraph 262) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to charity and responsibility: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 27 to the story's treatment of alienation in modern work: "Of all the fiery afternoon blunders and flurried rashnesses of Turkey, was his once moistening a ginger-cake between his lips, and clapping it on to a mortgage for a seal." Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 27) develops alienation in modern work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Its words "rashnesses" and "moistening" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "I resolved to assign Bartleby a corner by the folding-doors, but on my side of them, so as to have this quiet man…" (paragraph 33), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating alienation in modern work as central.

26. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 177 to the story's treatment of alienation in modern work: "I mean no mischief, seek the gratification of no heartless curiosity, thought I; besides, the desk is mine, and its contents too, so I will make bold to look within." Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 177) develops alienation in modern work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Its words "gratification" and "curiosity" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "And when at last it is perceived that such pity cannot lead to effectual succor, common sense bids the soul rid of it." (paragraph 179), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating alienation in modern work as central.

27. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 33 shapes its tone: "I resolved to assign Bartleby a corner by the folding-doors, but on my side of them, so as to have this quiet man within easy call, in case any trifling thing was to be done." Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words "trifling" and "resolved" (paragraph 33) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to charity and responsibility: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 297 shapes its tone: "Bartleby,' said I, entering the office, with a quietly severe expression, 'I am seriously displeased." Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words "expression" and "displeased" (paragraph 297) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to alienation in modern work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 24 to the story's treatment of alienation in modern work: "Or, if he wanted any thing, it was to be rid of a scrivener's table altogether." Use one other moment from the story as well.

Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 24) develops alienation in modern work: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Its words “scrivener's” and “altogether” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “The truth was, I suppose, that a man of so small an income, could not afford to sport such a lustrous face and a…” (paragraph 24), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating alienation in modern work as central.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 126 to the story's treatment of charity and responsibility: “So saying, Turkey rose to his feet and threw his arms into a pugilistic” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 126) develops charity and responsibility: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Its words “pugilistic” and “saying” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “His steadiness, his freedom from all dissipation, his incessant industry (except when he chose to throw himself into a…” (paragraph 169), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating charity and responsibility as central.

31. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] In the line “At any rate, upon the occasion in question, I strove to drown my exasperated feelings towards the scrivener by benevolently construing his conduct.”, what does “benevolently” most nearly mean?

    A. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies

    B. never seen before; unequaled

    C. pushed forward unwelcome

    D. in a kind, well-meaning way

    Key: D (in a kind, well-meaning way)

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 172 to the story's treatment of charity and responsibility: “Furthermore, I was full of uneasiness as to what Bartleby could possibly be doing in my office in his shirt sleeves, and in an otherwise dismantled condition of a Sunday morning.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 172) develops charity and responsibility: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Its words “uneasiness” and “dismantled” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “The cushioned seat of a rickety old sofa in one corner bore the faint impress of a lean, reclining form.” (paragraph 173), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating charity and responsibility as central.

33. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] In the line “These sad fancyings—chimeras, doubtless, of a sick and silly brain—led on to other and more special thoughts, concerning the eccentricities of Bartleby.”, what does “chimeras” most nearly mean?

    A. pushed forward unwelcome

    B. wild, impossible dreams or fantasies

    C. in a kind, well-meaning way

    D. never seen before; unequaled

    Key: B (wild, impossible dreams or fantasies)

34. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Connect this passage from paragraph 314 to the story's treatment of charity and responsibility: “Some days now passed, during which, at leisure intervals I looked a little into ‘Edwards on the Will,’ and ‘Priestly on Necessity.’ Under the circumstances, those books induced a salutary feeling.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 314) develops charity and responsibility: copying, repeated endlessly, strips Bartleby of meaning. Its words “circumstances” and “intervals” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Bartleby was one of those beings of whom nothing is ascertainable, except from the original sources, and in his case…” (paragraph 1), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating charity and responsibility as central.

Rigor version	**Items (in order)**	**Mix**
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 11, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	6, 8, 7, 1, 9, 11, 2, 4, 10, 3, 19, 12, 13, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23	recall 10, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	4, 9, 2, 10, 11, 6, 7, 12, 14, 19, 19, 13, 15, 24, 20, 21, 25, 26	recall 7, inference 6, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	1, 2, 11, 8, 3, 4, 19, 14, 13, 15, 12, 19, 21, 22, 27, 28, 26, 18	recall 6, inference 6, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	5, 1, 6, 7, 8, 15, 19, 19, 12, 13, 14, 28, 17, 20, 21, 29, 23, 30	recall 5, inference 6, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	10, 4, 31, 15, 12, 14, 19, 28, 20, 21, 17, 27, 16, 25, 18, 30, 32, 26	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Freshman	8, 33, 11, 14, 19, 12, 20, 17, 24, 27, 21, 28, 29, 26, 34, 18, 25, 30	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 6, synthesis 6
College Sophomore	4, 31, 33, 12, 13, 28, 20, 21, 22, 17, 24, 25, 29, 23, 18, 26, 34, 30	recall 3, inference 2, analysis 6, synthesis 7
College Junior	9, 33, 11, 19, 15, 24, 21, 16, 17, 20, 22, 23, 29, 30, 26, 32, 25, 34	recall 3, inference 2, analysis 6, synthesis 7
College Senior	1, 11, 31, 15, 20, 27, 17, 28, 21, 24, 32, 26, 25, 29, 18, 34, 30, 23	recall 3, inference 1, analysis 6, synthesis 8
Graduate / PhD	10, 11, 19, 17, 22, 20, 16, 24, 27, 28, 23, 26, 32, 34, 29, 25, 30, 18	recall 2, inference 1, analysis 7, synthesis 8

Final paper

Bartleby, the Scrivener: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Herman Melville develops passive resistance across Bartleby, the Scrivener. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in Bartleby, the Scrivener and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to alienation in modern work.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether Bartleby, the Scrivener finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of charity and responsibility. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor	Exemplary	Proficient	Developing	Beginning
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.	Specific, arguable and precise; it organizes every section.	Clear and arguable, but broad in places.	States a topic or a summary more than an argument.	Missing, or restates the prompt.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.	Accurate, well-chosen quotations from across the work, all cited; meets the requirement.	Accurate and cited, but clustered in one part of the work.	Too few quotations, or some inaccurate or uncited.	Little or no quoted evidence.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.	Explains how specific words, structure and devices create meaning; weighs a competing reading.	Explains the evidence, with some close reading.	Mostly summary; the link to the claim is asserted, not shown.	Summary only.
Organization	15					

		Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.	Each paragraph advances the argument; transitions show logic.	Logical order with minor jumps.	Order is loose; paragraphs repeat or drift.	No discernible structure.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.	Formal, precise, present tense; MLA format; virtually error-free.	Formal with a few errors that do not obscure meaning.	Informal or error-prone in ways that distract.	Errors obscure meaning.

Exemplar paragraph: The lawyer comes to see Bartleby's despair as a sign of a wider human condition. The text makes this visible when it says “Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men” (Bartleby, the Scrivener, paragraph 485). Hearing of the Dead Letter Office, he exclaims "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men," and ends "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity," linking one clerk to everyone. A full paper would carry this reading through the beginning, middle and end, and answer the strongest competing reading.

Essay assignments

Essay: Passive resistance

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Bartleby, the Scrivener teaches about passive resistance. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Herman Melville develops passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Herman Melville develops passive resistance across Bartleby, the Scrivener. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Bartleby, the Scrivener (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of passive resistance. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Herman Melville's choices in Bartleby, the Scrivener (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of passive resistance, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Bartleby, the Scrivener's treatment of passive resistance in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on passive resistance in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Alienation in modern work

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Bartleby, the Scrivener teaches about alienation in modern work. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Herman Melville develops alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Herman Melville develops alienation in modern work across Bartleby, the Scrivener. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Bartleby, the Scrivener (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of alienation in modern work. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Herman Melville's choices in Bartleby, the Scrivener (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of alienation in modern work, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Bartleby, the Scrivener's treatment of alienation in modern work in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Name your critical method, apply it closely,

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Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on alienation in modern work in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Charity and responsibility

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Bartleby, the Scrivener teaches about charity and responsibility. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Herman Melville develops charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Herman Melville develops charity and responsibility across Bartleby, the Scrivener. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Bartleby, the Scrivener (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of charity and responsibility. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Herman Melville's choices in Bartleby, the Scrivener (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of charity and responsibility, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Bartleby, the Scrivener's treatment of charity and responsibility in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener that reads the story against its genre and period and

engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on charity and responsibility in Bartleby, the Scrivener, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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